

THE DIAGNOSTICIAN'S METHOD

Lesson 3 · Resource 2 of 3

Resource 1 ended with a test: does the connection between the wound and the belief require an argument, or is it immediate? That test is the finish line. This resource is the route there.

You can't reason your way to a wound directly — reasoning alone gets you to something *plausible*, and plausible is exactly what you're trying to get past. What follows is a three-stage process built to do the opposite: narrow the search with logic, surface the actual material without logic, then use logic again — differently — to confirm you've found the real thing and not just the first thing that fit.

Stage 1 — Deductive Reasoning

Working backward from the belief.

Start with the hidden truth you locked in Lesson 2 and work backward. What type of experience could have taught this belief as a fact about reality — not a feeling, a fact? What relationships, contexts, or recurring moments would be capable of producing this exact conclusion in this character, at this age, with this history?

You're not looking for the answer yet. You're narrowing the territory. Deduction can tell you the *shape* of the wound before you know its specifics — whether it's more likely a single incident or a sustained pattern, whether it involves a person's presence or a person's absence, whether it happened to your character directly or was witnessed happening to someone else. That shape is what Stage 2 needs in order to find the actual scene.

Stage 2 — Intuitive Visualization

Listening before evaluating.

Stop reasoning. Ask the question quietly, and wait: when you picture your character at the age this belief was first forming — where are they? How old? Who else is present? What is happening, or what is persistently failing to happen?

This isn't guesswork, and it isn't mystical. Psychologist Timothy Wilson's research on what he calls the *adaptive unconscious* — the same research behind the anchor-behavior work you did in Lesson 1 — found that most of what we know about ourselves and the people we've built in our minds is processed below conscious awareness, and surfaces faster and more accurately through image than through analysis. Your character has been living in your head since before Lesson 1. Some part of you already knows this scene. Stage 2 is where you let it arrive instead of constructing it.

Take whatever surfaces, however partial or strange it seems. Don't edit it yet. That's Stage 3's job.

Stage 3 — Socratic Pressure

Finding the real wound, not the plausible one.

Now bring reasoning back — but pointed at the material Stage 2 produced, not generating new material of its own. Your coach takes the wound you've surfaced and challenges it against the same test Resource 1 ended on: is the connection to the hidden truth immediate, or does it need explaining? Is this scene specific enough that only this character could have drawn this conclusion from it? Could a different character, in the same circumstances, have reached a different belief?

This is the elenchus in practice — the same discipline behind every stage of this course. The first answer is a hypothesis, not a conclusion. If your coach has to reason through the connection with you, it isn't tight yet. Keep going. The wound that survives this stage is the one that needs no defense.

Confirming the Origin: The Wound-to-Belief Lock

Once a wound passes Stage 3, lock it with one sentence:

Because of this wound, my character concluded _____.

Read it back. The lock holds when the conclusion feels inevitable — not one reasonable response among several, but the only one this character could have reached. If completing the sentence requires you to explain your reasoning, the lock isn't tight. Go back to Stage 3.

Worked example — Katniss Everdeen:

Because of this wound — growing up in District 12, where the state could take anything and anyone at any moment, where her father died in a preventable accident and her mother disappeared into grief, leaving Katniss solely responsible for Prim's survival — her character concluded: no one will protect the people I love if I don't.

Notice what makes that lock hold without argument: the scene is specific (District 12, this father, this mother's grief, this sister), and the leap from scene to belief requires no bridge. You don't have to be convinced. You just see it.

The Causal Chain

When the lock holds, you have three layers, causally connected:

Wound → Hidden Truth → Anchor Behavior

The wound (today) explains the belief (Lesson 2). The belief explains the behavior (Lesson 1). Each layer accounts for the next without additional reasoning — that's what "causally locked" means in practice, and it's the foundation everything else in this course is built on top of.

Set aside real time for this session — the wound typically surfaces in the second half, after deduction has done its narrowing work. Don't cut Stage 2 short to get to a tidy answer faster. The tidy answer is usually the plausible one.

Next: Resource 3, Four Signs the Wound Hasn't Surfaced Yet — a field guide for recognizing, in the moment, when you're still one layer above the real thing.